

132. To these gods the Persians offer sacrifice in the following manner : they raise no altar, light no fire, pour no libations, there is no sound of the flute, no putting on of chaplets, no consecrated barley-cake ; but the man who wishes to sacrifice brings his victim to a spot of ground which is pure from pollution, and there calls upon the name of the god to whom he intends to offer. It is usual to have the turban encircled with a wreath, most commonly of myrtle. The sacrificer is not allowed to pray for blessings on himself alone, but he prays for the welfare of the king, and of the whole Persian people, among whom he is of necessity included. He cuts the victim in pieces, and having boiled the flesh, he lays it out upon the tenderest herbage that he can find, trefoil especially. When all is ready, one of the Magi comes forward and chants a hymn, which they say recounts the origin of the gods. It is not lawful to offer sacrifice unless there is a Magus present. After waiting a short time the sacrificer carries the flesh of the victim away with him, and makes whatever use of it he may please.⁷

brethren, worshipped the sun under the name of Mithra. This was a portion of the religion which they brought with them from the Indus, and was not adopted from any foreign nation. The name of Mithra does not indeed occur in the Achæmenian inscriptions until the time of Artaxerxes Mnemon (*Journal of Asiatic Society*, vol. xv. part. i. p. 160), but there is no reason to question the antiquity of his worship in Persia. Xenophon is right in making it a part of the religion of Cyrus (*Cyrop.* viii. iii. § 12, and vii. § 3).

The mistake of Herodotus does not appear to have been discovered by the Greeks before the time of Alexander. Xenophon, indeed, mentions Mithras (*Cyrop.* vii. v. § 53 ; *Econ.* iv. 24), and also the Persian sun-worship (*Cyrop.* viii. iii. § 12), but he does not in any way connect the two. Strabo is the first classical writer who distinctly lays it down that the Persian Mithras is the Sun-god (xv. p. 1039). After him Plutarch shows acquaintance with the fact (*Vit. Alex.* c. 30), which thenceforth becomes generally recognised. (See the inscriptions on altars, *DEO SOLI INVICTO MITHRÆ*, &c., and cf. Suidas, Hesychius, &c.)

The real representative of Venus in the later Pantheon of Persia was Tanata or Anaitis (see Hyde, *De Religione Vet. Pers.* p. 98). Her worship by the Persians had, no doubt, commenced in the time of Herodotus, but it was not till the reign of Artaxerxes Mnemon (B. C. 405 at the earliest) that her statue was set up publicly in the temples of the chief cities of the empire (*Plut. Artaxerx.* c. 27). The inscription of Mnemon recently discovered at Susa records this event (*Journal of Asiatic Soc.*, l. s. c.), which seems to have been wrongly ascribed by Berosus to Artaxerxes Ochus (*Beros. ap. Clem. Alex. Protr.* i. 5).

⁷ At the secret meetings of the Ali Allahis of Persia, which in popular belief have attained an infamous notoriety, but which are in reality altogether innocent, are practised many ceremonies that bear a striking resemblance to the old Magian sacrifice.

The *Peer* or holy man who presides carries about him sprigs both of myrtle and of the musk willow ; he seats his disciples in a circle upon the grass usually in one of those sacred groves with which the Kurdish mountains abound ; he chaunts mystical lays regarding the nature, the attributes, and the manifestations of the Godhead. A sheep is slaughtered as an expiatory sacrifice, and the carcase is boiled upon the spot ; the bones are carefully extracted, and the peer then distributes the flesh among his disciples, who creep up upon their knees from their respective